new alliance which he hoped would keep him in power and leave Akbar Khan isolated.

The two men Shuja reached out to brought very different assets to the table. As Akbar Khan's uncle, Nawab Zaman Khan was a senior claimant to the Barakzai succession, and controlled the valuable asset of all the British sick and wounded left in Kabul; but he had few financial or intellectual resources and little military ability. The elderly but still canny Naib Aminullah Khan Logari, in contrast, had made a fortune through trade which he had recently augmented with the large sums he managed to extract from the Hindu bankers of Kabul on the basis of the bills given to him by the retreating British as part of their surrender. He used this to recruit a force of sepoys as well as pay his own tribesmen from Logar. He also had the prestige of being one of the two military leaders responsible for so comprehensively crushing the British in Kabul. But being neither a Sadozai nor a Barakzai, and of relatively humble origins, he was apparently unable to come to power without the support of one or other of the two leading clans. By allying with Nawab Zaman Khan and Shah Shuja he was able to gain the support of both.[13] Naib Aminullah had always been a confirmed Sadozai loyalist, while Nawab Zaman Khan detested his charismatic cousin Akbar with all the embittered passion that the ambitiously mediocre sometimes feel towards those of genuine talent. The alliance looked durable as it gave something to all three of the parties involved and each brought something to it that the others needed.

According to his biographer Mohammad Husain Herati, Shuja had planned the whole strategy with flawless precision. 'The Barakzai propaganda that His Majesty had become indistinguishable from the English invaders had taken root among great and small alike,' he wrote.

> In order to counter this, and following advice that the only way out of the present rebellion which threatened to destroy the monarchy was to conciliate the good graces of Aminullah Khan Logari, His Majesty decided to send his favourite and most gifted son Prince Shahpur to the house of Aminullah. He also promised a gift of 200,000 rupees to Nawab Zaman Khan Barakzai. So it was that Aminullah and most of the other Khans now came to support His Majesty, saying that the Nawab had been elected Amir while it seemed that His Majesty was subservient to foreign and infidel interests, but now that he had regained his independence, and was once again a true Muslim monarch, there was no need for an Amir, and Zaman Khan would have to be content with the post of Wazir which was a powerful enough position. Akbar Khan was not party to this new alliance.